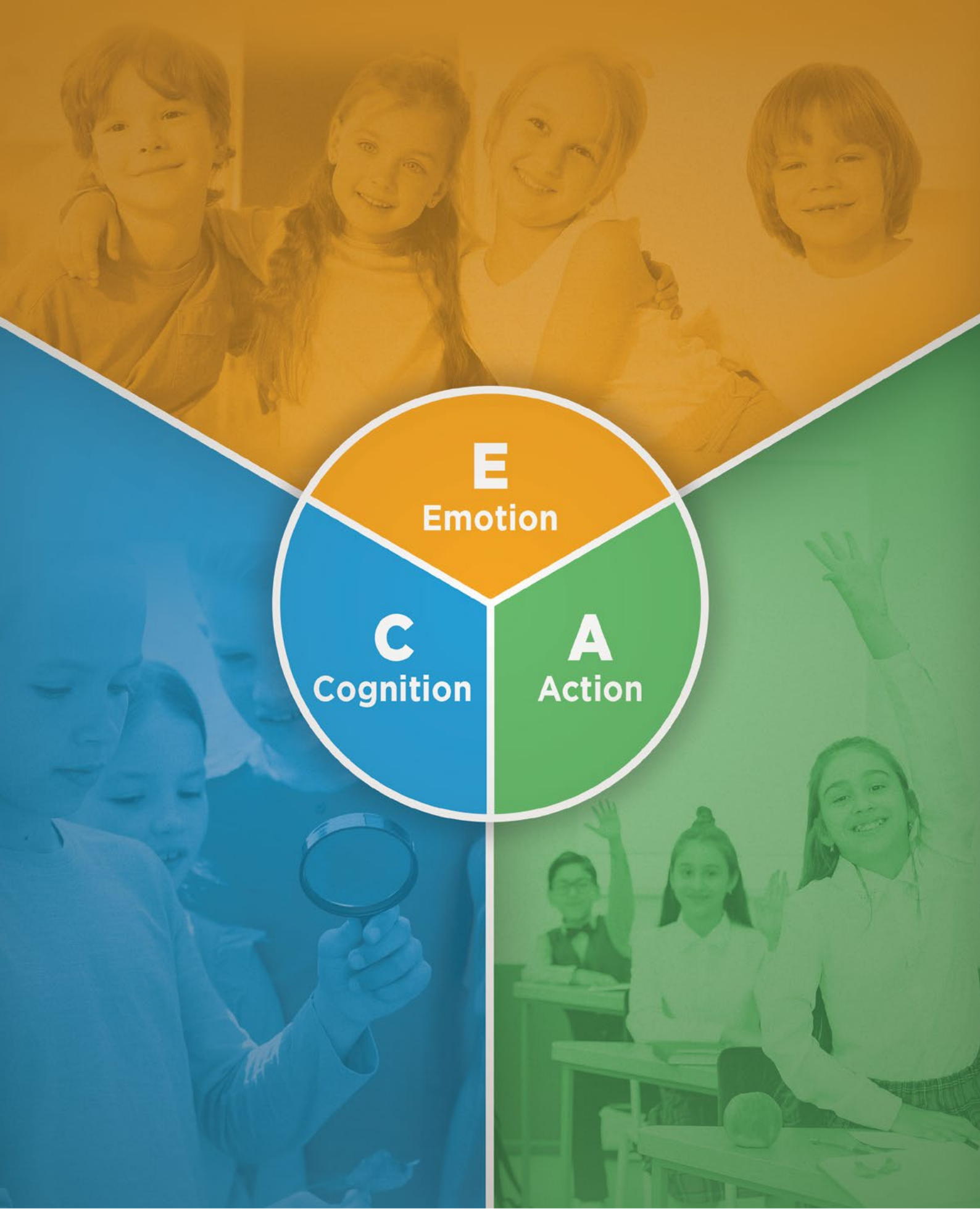


ECA BEST PRACTICE GUIDELINES

Author:
Katalin Csizmazia

The full name of the Meseliget Foundation's project is:
Developing a Skill Building Balanced Emotion, Cognition and Action

Publisher: Meseliget Foundation

Project's number: 2025-1-HU01-KA210-SCH-000360331

The project was carried out in collaboration with
the Polish partner organization Gedania1922

Call for proposals (start) date: 2025

AI Disclosure: Generative Artificial Intelligence tools (ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, HeyGen, Napkin AI) were used in the production and translation of the content in this document. AI was utilized solely as a supportive tool: all outputs were validated based on our own sources, subjected to expert review, and modified as necessary. The project implementers maintain full responsibility for the accuracy and originality of the final content.

Open licence
This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International Licence (CC BY-SA 4.0).

Co-funded by the European Union

Funded by the European Union. Views and opinions expressed are however those of the author(s) only and do not necessarily reflect those of the European Union or the European Education and Culture Executive Agency (EACEA). Neither the European Union nor EACEA can be held responsible for them.

Contents

1. **About these Guidelines** 4

2. **What Makes an ECA Learning Experience?** . . .5

3. **Looking at Learning through ECA** 6

4. **Postcards from Practice: What we learnt from educators using ECA** 7

5. **Six Traps We Encountered** 9

6. **Where to Continue** **10**

1.
About these Guidelines

These guidelines grew out of the practical experience of the ECA – Emotion, Cognition, Action Erasmus+ project, developed by the Meseliget Foundation and Gedania 1922 from Poland. They bring together some of the most important lessons we learnt while developing, piloting, adapting and using ECA in different educational settings.

ECA was tested in classrooms, workshops, teacher training, university programmes, camps, gardens, outdoor activities and community events. These experiences helped us understand what works, what difficulties emrged, what needs adaptation and what educators should pay particular attention to. The guidelines are therefore intended as a practical companion to the ECA Curriculum, Handbook, Training Programme and teaching materials – something to browse, question and return to when designing your own ECA learning experiences.

2.
What Makes an ECA Learning Experience?

ECA provides a **clear and consistent structure: Emotion – Cognition – Action.**

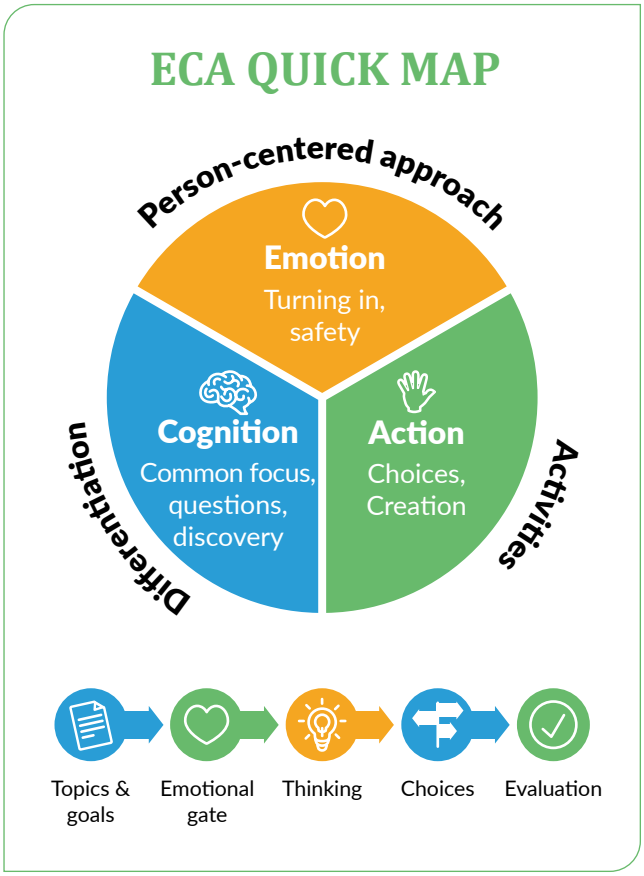
Emotion creates personal connection, curiosity, motivation and emotional safety.

Cognition invites learners to observe, question, understand, connect ideas and think critically.

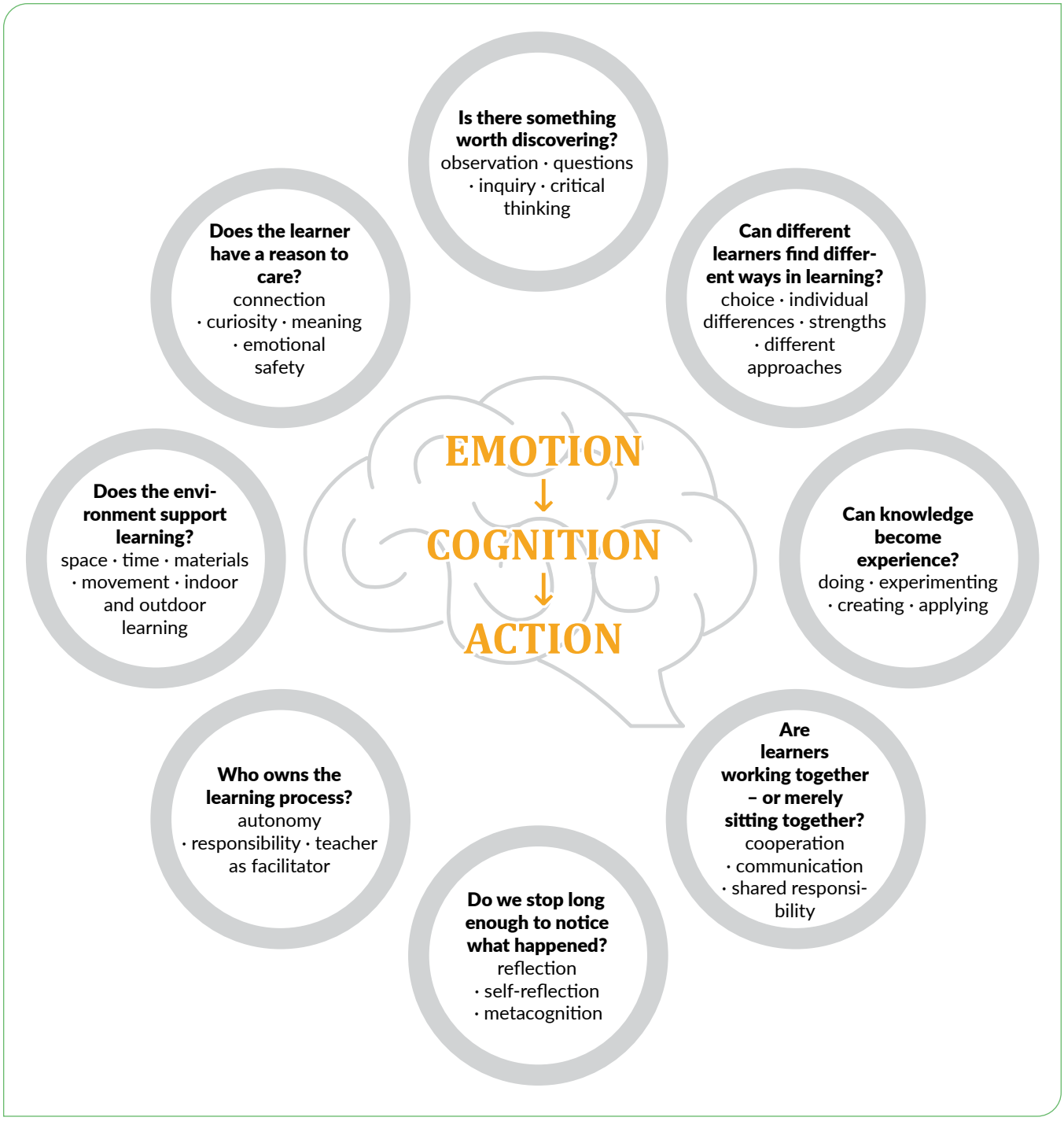
Action gives them opportunities to experiment, create, cooperate, apply knowledge and influence their environment.

The three elements belong to one learning process. They should not be treated as three unrelated activities or as boxes to tick. The content, activities, methods and learning environment can be adapted to different learners, subjects, ages and educational settings.

At its heart, ECA asks a simple question: **How can learning engage the whole person – feeling, thinking and acting?**



3.
Looking at Learning through ECA



These questions are interconnected: a strong ECA learning experience is created not by isolated techniques, but by the relationships between emotion, thinking, action, people and environment.

4.
Postcards from Practice: What we learnt from educators using ECA

ECA has been used in very different environments: conventional lessons, longer learning sessions, teacher training, university education, school gardens, camps, outdoor programmes and community events. This diversity confirmed something important. The E–C–A structure remains the same, but its practical expression can look very different depending on the learners, the available time, the environment and the purpose of the activity. We made plans, but very many useful lessons came not from what educators and learners experienced while actually using ECA.

POSTCARD 1: 45 minutes can be very short

Offering different activities and genuine choices can be difficult within a conventional 45-minute lesson. Preparation takes time, different groups may need different materials, and one teacher cannot support several processes simultaneously.

WHAT WE LEARNT

Do not give up choice – design it realistically. Teachers experimented with asking learners to choose their activities in advance. They also extended activities for more than one lesson.



POSTCARD 2 : "We are never allowed to make fire!"

During a Jurtasuli camp, children built an open air oven and were involved in making and managing the fire. When reflecting on the experience, one child said that this was what he had particularly enjoyed – because children are usually not allowed to do it. The comment revealed something beyond enjoyment. The child had been trusted with a real activity involving responsibility, attention and risk.

WHAT WE LEARNT

Action becomes particularly powerful when it is authentic. Children notice the difference between an exercise created for them and being trusted to participate in something real.

(Rogers Jurtasuli, Érd)



POSTCARD 3: Choice needs preparation

Giving learners different pathways through the same topic was highly valued, but it also increased the preparation required from teachers. Several simultaneous activities may mean different materials, spaces and forms of support.

WHAT WE LEARNT

Person-centred learning does not mean thirty individual lesson plans. A small number of meaningful, well-prepared options can already change learners' relationship to a task.

(Ceglédi Táncsics Mihály Általános iskola)

POSTCARD 4: Reflection sometimes changed who spoke

Reflection became one of the most valuable elements of ECA activities. When reflection questions focused on personal experience, learning strategies, cooperation or individual observations rather than on finding one correct answer, some learners who rarely spoke during conventional classroom discussions became more active and shared their thoughts with the group.

WHAT WE LEARNT

Do not treat reflection as an optional ending when there is time left. Reflection is where experience can become conscious learning.

(Formabontó, Göd))



POSTCARD 5: The environment changed the lesson

Gardens, camps and outdoor settings often made Action easier and more natural. Learners could observe real phenomena, work with natural materials, build, grow, investigate and respond to situations that had not been planned in advance.

WHAT WE LEARNT

The learning environment is not simply the place where education happens. It can become one of its resources.

(Rogers Jurtasui, Érd)



POSTCARD 6: Teachers adapted ECA

One of the strongest signs that ECA was becoming usable was when educators began adapting them to their own needs: changing questions, timing, materials or forms of Action to suit their own learners.

WHAT WE LEARNT

Successful implementation does not mean copying an ECA activity exactly. It means understanding the E–C–A structure well enough to design within it

(Formabontó, Gód)

POSTCARD 5: Reflection is interesting – until someone is talking

One teacher noticed a difficulty during reflection: children were enthusiastic when it was their turn to speak, but quickly lost interest when they had to listen to their classmates.

WHAT WE LEARNT

Reflection needs facilitation: varied formats (pairs, small gorups, planery), focused questions and activities that give learners a reason to respond to, build on or connect with what others have said.

(Ceglédi Táncsics Mihály Általános iskola)

5.
Six Traps We Encountered

1. THE FEELING TRAP: "How do you feel?"

Emotion is about connection, curiosity, safety, motivation and personal meaning. Asking about feelings can be useful, but Emotion should not become a compulsory emotional check-in.

TRY INSTEAD: Create something worth caring about.

2. THE CRAFT TRAP: Action ≠ handicraft

Making something can be excellent Action – when making has a purpose. But Action can also mean experimenting, deciding, investigating, solving, changing something or applying knowledge.

TRY INSTEAD: Ask: What can learners actually do with what they have understood?

3. THE FAKE CHOICE TRAP: Choice must be real

Offering choice is not person-centred if only one option is genuinely acceptable or achievable.

TRY INSTEAD: Offer fewer choices, but make each one meaningful.

4. THE LABEL TRAP: A framework is not a label

Multiple Intelligences, MBTI and other frameworks can help us notice differences. They become limiting when we use them to decide permanently what kind of learner somebody is.

TRY INSTEAD: Use frameworks to expand possibilities, not reduce people to categories.

5. THE CHAOS TRAP: Facilitation ≠ absence of structure

A person-centred teacher does not disappear. Learners need clear boundaries, appropriate resources, thoughtful questions and professional support. Sometimes even control.

TRY INSTEAD: Create a strong framework within which learners can have genuine autonomy.

6. THE CHECKLIST TRAP: ECA ≠ three boxes to tick

Emotion, Cognition and Action provide a clear structure, but forcing an artificial E, C and A activity into a lesson does not automatically create meaningful learning.

TRY INSTEAD: Look at the relationship between the three: does connection lead towards understanding, and can understanding open possibilities for action?

6.
Where to Continue

The project produced a wider set of resources for educators who would like to explore the approach in greater depth or adapt it to their own practice.

The **ECA Curriculum** provides the pedagogical framework and explores the theoretical backgorund.

We encourage educators not simply to reproduce these materials, but to **experiment with them, adapt them and create their own ECA learning experiences.** ECA began with three words: **Emotion. Cognition. Action.** The most important question is what they can become in your own learning environment.

Further resources:

- The **Teacher's Handbook** adds practical approaches in greater depth.
- The **Training Programme** supports professional development
- The Science for Small kids
- The Eca cards
- The project's teaching materials and lesson plans provide concrete examples of ECA in practice.
- The website
- Results page
- Epale pages